AMBIGUOUS BEAUTY: CURATORIAL NOTES ON THE TACTILE GAZE

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Introduction

Ambiguous Beauty, a thematic grouping of fifty-six artworks that engage with queer aesthetics, relation, and embodiment in the permanent collection of the Smart Museum of Art, was the culmination of my research assistantship at the Smart with Dr. Orianna Cacchione, Curator of Global Contemporary Art. My original goal was to study other museums' exhibition strategies and to present an intervention into the Smart's virtual collection. What I ended up proposing through the curation of *Ambiguous Beauty* was not a particular display strategy but a different way of looking. Central to this project was a notion of queerness as an explicit refusal of meaning, which I took as the basis from which I constructed the proposed framework. This way of looking and its ethical stakes, provisionally named ***the tactile gaze, pits description against the temptation of readymade perspectives*** — to quote curator and art historian Darby English — and ***deliberately invites illegibility and ambiguity into the consideration of a work of art***. Translating the grammar of the caress into the field of vision, the tactile gaze is a way of seeing that opens towards otherness. The gaze and the thematic grouping, as theory and practice, emerge simultaneously through my encounters with artworks that invite reflection and inquiry, precisely because of their difficulty, distance, and ambivalence.

Methodology

This project came into being at the intersection of multiple trajectories. It is motivated by the slapstick of ordinary relation as lived by a queer & trans migrant. It employs formalism and materiality as methods of describing art. Its theoretical framework is an intentionally disruptive reading of Emmanuel Levinas' notion of the caress to generate a queer ethics of relating and becoming. It engages with existing scholarship on interpretation, the phenomenology of touch, and queer theory, with Leo Bersani, Maurice Merleau-Ponty, and Hélène Cixous as primary interlocutors.

Case study

Consider this self-portrait by Sophie Thun, which the Smart describes as presenting "dominant and submissive positions of sexual acts" in the interpretation packet that accompanies the *Smart to the Core: Medium/Image* exhibition. However, the photograph resists this prescriptive reading. Thun's doubles are shown in profile, bodies perpendicular to the camera, faces turned towards us. The bottom figure is bent over a white dishwasher, while the top figure is slightly crouched above it. If the description in the label text is motivated by a reading of these bodies as penetrator and penetrated, penetration itself is absent from the image. The imagined site of sexual contact is completely obscured by the diagonal cut of the collage. Furthermore, the penetrator/penetrated dyad does not directly and straightforwardly map onto the dominant/submissive dyad. Being penetrated can be active, even commanding: consider the dominatrix who orders her submissive to penetrate her. The proposed relation between these bodies depends on a mapping that completely elides what is present in the photograph and in lived erotic behavior.

Yasumasa Morimura, *Ambiguous Beauty / Aimai-no-bi* (1995)
The thematic grouping is named after this work.

On the caress

"*The caress does not know what it seeks… [Eros is a] not-knowing, a game absolutely without project or plan, not with what can become ours or us but with something other, always other, always inaccessible, and always still to come.*"
Emmanuel Levinas, *Time and the Other* (1987)

The caress is a useful analogy to describe a way of looking that is not yoked to knowledge-production, because the caress is a non-teleological mode of relation. Here, the infinite excess of meaning situated in the Other is not an epistemological challenge to be surmounted, but a potential for radical alterity, expression, pleasure, and play. Furthermore, resisting the urge to interpret that which we encounter along familiar discourses (of positionality, sexuality, etc.) as "what can become ours or us" and accepting its alterity allows us to be affected beyond the level of comprehension and to be ***touched***. To look with love at an Other that is absolutely different from me, whether this Other is an artwork, an event, or a person, is to allow for queerness where one may grasp for familiarity. The tactile gaze, as a methodological approach, is an insistence on accommodating the ambivalent, illegible, and difficult in our encounters with art, at the expense of normalizing frameworks of relation, in order to capacitate new horizons of sensations, reactions, and becomings.

Tenets of the Tactile Gaze

The tactile gaze is "wary of holism,
but needy for connection."

It does not exist as a pure idea;
it emerges from the difficulty of encounter.

It is a look that caresses.

It is looking-with-love.

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